Luca Looser
Curriculum vitae

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Placement Officer	Edouard Schaal

Education

2023 –	Universitat Pompeu Fabra, Ph.D. Candidate in Economics Expected completion: June 2027 Advisors: Elisa Giannone and Dávid Krisztián Nagy
2022 – 2023	Universitat Pompeu Fabra, MRes in Economics, Finance and Management
2021 – 2022	Barcelona School of Economics, MSc in Economics (PhD Track)
2020 – 2021	London School of Economics, MSc in Economics
2015 – 2019	University of St. Gallen, B.A. in Economics
2017 – 2018	Keio University, Exchange Program

Research fields

Primary:	Macro Development
Secondary:	Economic Geography, Macroeconomics

Research experience

2024 –	Short-Term Consultant for Tatjana Kleineberg, World Bank
2023 – 2024	Research Assistant for Prof. Paula Bustos, Universitat Pompeu Fabra

Teaching experience

Undergraduate

2023	Microeconomics I, Universitat Pompeu Fabra
2023	International Economics I, Universitat Pompeu Fabra

Professional experience

2019 – 2020	Intern, Inflation Forecasting Unit, Swiss National Bank
2018 – 2019	Student Assistant for Statistical Analysis, University of St. Gallen

Research visits

Aug.–Sep. 2026	Washington University in St. Louis Host: Francisco Buera

Presentations

2026	UPF Applied Lunch; CREi International Lunch; 8th QMUL Economics and Finance Workshop; 2nd EUI ECO PhD Workshop; HEC Economics PhD Conference; XXIX Workshop on Dynamic Macroeconomics; 20th North American Meeting of the Urban Economics Association; LAEF Growth, Inequality, and Macro Development Conference; OxDev 2026; WashU Macro Breakfast; SAEe 2026*
2025	BSE Jamboree; CREi International Lunch; 20th End-of-Year Conference of Swiss Economists Abroad
2023 – 2024	CREi International Lunch

* Scheduled.

Research

Job Market Paper

From Roots to Branches: The Role of Families in Structural Change

Economic opportunities differ sharply across sectors and places, but workers face barriers to reaching them. Kinship can reinforce these barriers when relatives remain in current sectors and origins, yet kin in expanding sectors and at destinations can facilitate adjustment. I study this feedback during U.S. structural transformation from 1880 to 1970. I reconstruct extended kin for 32 million individuals and use deaths of relatives to show that sector-employed kin increase same-sector employment and local kin reduce migration, while migrants disproportionately move toward destinations where relatives already live. I embed these forces in a dynamic spatial model in which workers' choices reshape the connections available to other kin and later generations. Kin account for roughly 10–15 percent of sectoral and migration barriers. Their initial concentration in agriculture and less industrialized places slows structural transformation, but subsequent sector switching and migration offset 55% of this drag by 1950 and about 90% by 1970, raising the 1970 manufacturing share by 2.05 percentage points. In a relocation-voucher counterfactual, ignoring kin spillovers understates the long-run manufacturing effect by 33%, while the same budget induces about three times as many moves when more kin already live at eligible destinations.

Working Papers

Unequal Global Convergence
with Shoumitro Chatterjee, Elisa Giannone, Tatjana Kleineberg and Kan Kuno

We revisit the role of structural transformation in regional convergence using a new global dataset covering more than 1,500 regions in over 90 countries since 1980. Regional convergence declines over time and stalls in the most recent decade despite substantial remaining spatial inequality. This decline is associated with structural transformation toward high-skill services, which are more geographically concentrated than agriculture, manufacturing or other services. A spatial equilibrium model shows how the shift toward high-skill services can reinforce agglomeration and weaken regional convergence.

The Intergenerational Benefits of a Temporary Negative Shock: Evidence from Import Restrictions in Thailand
with Chanont Banternghansa and Elisa Giannone

We exploit a temporary, sector-specific import restriction in Thailand to study the long-run consequences of a short-lived negative demand shock. Exposed shrimp farmers experience large initial income losses, but the adjustment persists after the direct shock has disappeared: affected households remain more likely to leave shrimp production and accumulate assets in new sectors. The consequences differ across generations and adjustment margins. Producers who remain in the sector benefit as competitors exit, while younger members of households that reallocate experience improvements in education. The results show how a temporary shock can generate persistent sectoral reallocation and intergenerational effects.

Inheriting Geography: Marriage and the Geography of Opportunity

Using linked complete-count U.S. censuses from 1880 to 1950, I study how marriage reshapes family geography and how these new spatial connections affect where families live across generations. Marriage substantially expands the set of family-connected places, and within-family comparisons show that spouses' relatives shift where couples settle and where their children later live. A quantitative model shows that family ties increase intergenerational spatial persistence, primarily by shaping where parents establish the household.

Grants and fellowships

2026	STEG-BSE Research Grant
2021 – 2023	GPEFM PhD Track Fellowship, Universitat Pompeu Fabra

Professional service

2023 – 2024	Co-Organizer, Student Seminar, Universitat Pompeu Fabra
	Referee, *The B.E. Journal of Macroeconomics*

IT and language skills

Programming
Stata, MATLAB, Python, R, LaTeX

Languages
German (native), Italian (native), English (fluent), French (intermediate), Spanish (B2), Japanese (A2)

References

Elisa Giannone (Advisor)
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Dávid Krisztián Nagy (Advisor)
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